CAREER GLITCH · SHORT · SIMPLE · NO BORING PARTS

# PARALEGAL IN THE AI ERA

The openings are real. The growth isn't — and the first rung is exactly what legal AI was built to eat.

**★ TL;DR — NO. Median $62,890 — call it ~$63K (BLS, Paralegals and Legal Assistants, May 2025), growth 0% through 2035 — and BLS says in plain text that demand is limited by advances in technology, including AI. The ~40,800 openings a year are replacements, not a future. The roadmap below is the way OUT: the brain that reads case files and explains process is worth more in a room that's growing. ★**

## THE CAREER GLITCH TAKE

OUR TAKE: NO — NOT IN 2027

MEDIAN ~$63K · TRAINING 1-2 years · AI RISK MEDIUM · CERTIFICATE

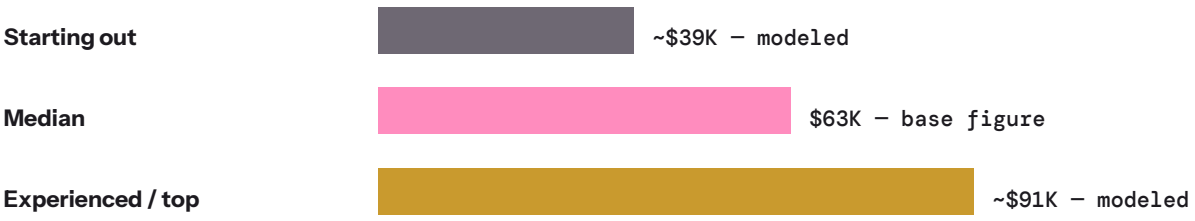
- Fails as a start because: growth is 0% for a decade (BLS, 2025–35) — the field hires ~40,800 people a year almost entirely to replace leavers, and BLS itself names AI as the brake on demand.

- The exposure problem: legal is the #2 most AI-exposed sector in Goldman Sachs' model — 44% of legal tasks could be automated — and document review, research memos and standard drafting, the junior layer, are precisely those tasks.

- Still worth money: the judgment layer. Reading a file and spotting what's missing, then explaining the process to a human — training rooms and credentialed practice pay for exactly that combination.

The site's take, built from this profession's numbers in the Career Glitch base.

## THE MONEY — LOOK AT THE BARS



The Career Glitch base figure for Paralegal is a ~$63K median (compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). The starting and top bars are modeled around that median — orientation, not a promise. Pay swings hard by state, employer and experience: check live postings in your state before planning around any number.

## WHAT DOES A PARALEGAL ACTUALLY DO?

- ✓ Research cases, rules and public records; draft documents attorneys sign
- ✓ Organize discovery and case files; track deadlines, filings and hearings
- ✓ Summarize records and depositions into briefs a lawyer can act on
- ✓ Explain process and paperwork to clients who are having a bad month

Think: a detective's evidence clerk with a law library — meticulous, trusted, and standing in the exact layer the new legal AI tools were built to absorb.

## WHAT AI ALREADY TOOK (AND WHAT IT CAN'T)

| THE ROBOT | THE HUMAN |
|---|---|
| Document review, discovery search, first-draft memos, standard contracts, deposition summaries. The bottom rungs of the junior ladder — the ones every 2027 entrant would start on. | Judgment about what a file is missing, confidentiality you can trust, and explaining legal process to a stressed human in plain words. That explaining part is quietly the most valuable — it's a training skill wearing a legal costume. |

⚠ **THE REPLACEMENT-OPENINGS MIRAGE: ~40,800 openings a year sounds like demand. It's churn — people leaving a flat field. Entering a 0%-growth occupation because the door still revolves means competing with every experienced paralegal the AI tools just made faster.**

## THE VIBE — IS THIS YOUR LIFE?

| THE JOB IS | THE JOB IS NOT |
|---|---|
| ✓ Detail-dense, investigative work where a missed date has real consequences<br>✓ Structured days, clear standards, credentials firms genuinely respect<br>✓ Client contact that is mostly explaining, calming and translating legal into human | ✗ Not growing: 0% for a decade, with the government itself blaming AI<br>✗ Not the safe rung it used to be: the entry tasks are the automation layer now<br>✗ Not authority: heavy responsibility, zero license to give legal advice |

Good fit? Already a paralegal doing senior, judgment-heavy work — complex litigation support, client strategy, a specialty firms can't staff. For you the exit is a sideways promotion, not a rescue. Bad fit? Anyone starting a certificate in 2027 because 'law is stable and AI-proof.' It was. The stability story ended; the tuition bills didn't get the memo.

## THE FORK — PICK ONE DOOR

| DOOR A — PIVOT TO Corporate Trainer | DOOR B — PIVOT TO Enrolled Agent (tax pro) |
|---|---|
| BLS Training and Development Specialists: median $69,280, growth +11% — much faster than average — with ~46,000 openings a year (2025–35). The bridge is real: paralegals already brief attorneys, walk clients through procedure and turn dense rules into plain steps. That is training — you've been doing it without the title. AI can generate course content, but it can't run the room, see the confusion and fix it live. First move: turn one process you know cold — client intake, discovery deadlines — into a 30-minute session and deliver it to anyone who will sit still. | BLS Tax Preparers category: median $54,920, growth +5–6%. The starting median is lower than paralegal pay — what you're buying is the license. The Enrolled Agent credential is the IRS's highest: a 3-part SEE exam and unlimited rights to represent taxpayers before the IRS, a regulated gate AI can't walk through. The transferable stack is direct: research, document discipline, penalty-grade deadlines, and explaining rules to stressed clients. First move: check your SEE eligibility and sit one practice section — credentialed preparers get hired every tax season. |

Smart move: If you stay: climb out of the task layer. Own client relationships and complex matters, and pick specialties with a queue — federal practice pays an $81,470 industry median (BLS). Senior judgment still bills; junior task work is what the software eats.
Where you land after: You land where explaining and credentials pay: running the training room, or holding an IRS credential with your name on the representation letter. Either way, the machine drafts for you — it doesn't replace you.

## YOUR ROADMAP — 6 STEPS

| 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 | 6 |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| ADMIT THE | INVENTORY YOUR | BUILD ONE | LEARN THE | GET A | APPLY AS |

### STEP 1 — Admit the field is flat

FREE · TODAY

- Read the BLS page yourself: 0% growth, and the AI sentence is right there in print
- Your asset isn't the certificate plan — it's the explaining-and-organizing brain. That's what moves

### STEP 2 — Inventory your teaching reps

FREE · 1 WEEK

- List every time you briefed a colleague, onboarded someone or walked a client through a process
- Pick the one process you could teach tomorrow with no notes

### STEP 3 — Build one teachable asset

FREE · 2 WEEKS

- Turn that process into a 30-minute session: an outline, one exercise, one checklist
- Deliver it once — a colleague, a community group, a camera. Awkward counts

### STEP 4 — Learn the trainer's toolkit

SELF-PACED · 2-3 WEEKS

- Needs analysis, session design, and how to tell whether anyone actually learned
- Map each skill onto the briefs and trainings you have already run informally

### STEP 5 — Get a live rep

FREE · 3-4 WEEKS

- Offer one free training to a firm, nonprofit or small business — onboarding and compliance topics always hurt
- Capture proof: attendance, feedback, one before-and-after number

### STEP 6 — Apply as a trainer

FREE · ONGOING

- Corporate trainer and training-specialist roles; lead with the session and the feedback, not the paralegal title
- Keep Door B warm: if the license route pulls harder, the SEE exam is a parallel track, not a detour

## FIRST 90 DAYS — JUST DO THIS

- Today: read the 0% yourself, then list your teaching reps. The second list is the career.
- Days 1–30: build the 30-minute session, deliver it once, start trainer fundamentals.
- Days 31–60: run one real training for a real group; collect feedback and a number.
- Days 61–90: apply to training roles with the asset and the proof — or register for the SEE if Door B wins.
- Day 90: you're a trainer with a delivered session on record — not a new student at the back of a flat field's queue.

## NEXT — MAKE IT PERSONAL

This roadmap is the same for everyone. Your life is not.

- Not sure this career fits YOU? Take the Big Career Test — 50 questions, your top-3 matches and one honest “probably NOT you”. → careerglitch.com/#test
- Already sure? Turn AI into Your Personal Career Mentor — a 2,300-word system that interviews you first, checks your hours, budget and deadline honestly, and builds YOUR plan into a Notion dashboard. → careerglitch.com/#prompt

★ THE EXPLAINER OUTLIVES THE FILER ★

CAREER GLITCH · Figures: Career Glitch profession base (medians and training ranges compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). Modeled bars are estimates around the base median. License and certification rules vary by state — verify with your state board before paying for any program.